if these voyages had been sustained. Zheng He and his voyages, though episodic, are part of a contemporary discourse which projects China not only as a continental power but as a maritime power too since ancient times. We shall consider China's history as a maritime power in Chapters 9 and 10.

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A second important prop in the Chinese narrative also picks up a phrase popularized by a Western scholar to highlight Chinese centrality as a pre-eminent trading power in history, with trade routes radiating outwards from the Chinese empire, to the west towards the Mediterranean through Central Asia, and to the east via the maritime route. The term the 'Silk Road' was first used in 1877 by the explorer Ferdinand von Richthofen and became popular in the twentieth century, as Central Asia became the focus of general exploration and also archaeological explorations by Westerners like Sven Hedin, Aurel Stein and Paul Pelliot.

The use of the word 'Silk' seemed to suggest that there was a single route from western China towards the West, on which the main commodity traded was Chinese silk. In fact, what is now known as the Silk Road in shorthand refers to a whole network of intersecting caravan routes which connected several countries and along which several commodities were transported and traded. The countries included China, but also Central Asian kingdoms, the Indian subcontinent, Persia, the Arab lands and the Mediterranean littoral, in particular the Roman empire. The maritime routes linked China's eastern coast with South-East Asia and India, and on the western flank linked India with Persia, the Arab countries, eastern Africa and the Mediterranean. In both cases, China was at the periphery and nowhere a nodal point.

The commodities carried along these intersecting routes were of enormous variety, including Chinese silk, jade and porcelain, but also Indian cottons, precious gems, pepper and other spices (both from India and South-East Asia). Horses from Central Asia, especially from Ferghana, were greatly prized and were imported by both India and China, and also by